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'Seeing' the Divine Image and Temple

6



Hindus visit a temple for *darshan*, or 'seeing' the image of the enshrined deity. Such seeing does not literally mean merely using one's eyes, but is a dynamic act of awareness. This type of 'seeing' lies behind the choice of 'seer' to designate a holy prophet or sage. The deity, in presenting itself for *darshan*, bestows blessings upon worshippers who, by their act of seeing, have made themselves receptive to this transfer of grace. The concept of *darshan* lies at the heart of the creation of images of the divine and of temples to enshrine them. ✓

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A scene at
a shrine,
Murshidabad,
c.1760.
Gouache with
gold on paper;
25.3 × 33.3 cm,
10 × 13 in.
British Library,
London

The multiple religious traditions of India resulted in an exuberant exploration of the possibilities of divine imagery. To comprehend and appreciate such a scenario, it is essential to set aside the deep-rooted Judeo-Christian distrust of icons traceable to the Biblical admonition against 'graven images', as well as the pejorative connotations of the words idol and idolatry. The *Vishnu Samhita*, an ancient Hindu ritual text, persuasively endorses the use of imagery (ch 29, v 55-7):

Without a form, how can God be meditated upon?

Where will the mind fix itself?

When there is nothing for the mind to attach itself to, it will slip away from meditation or will glide into a state of slumber.

Therefore the wise will meditate on some form

Many are perplexed by the multifarious profusion of Hindu temple images. Despite historical acceptance of multiple deities, the Hindu focus at any particular ritual is always upon one single deity invested with all the attributes of divinity. For the duration of the worship, none other exists. Hindus accept many gods because they accept many perspectives. To them, monotheism is but one avenue. In seeking to explain their outlook, Hindus today may suggest that the Infinite is like a ✓

diamond of innumerable sparkling facets, one facet appealing to an individual more forcefully than another. By adoring that facet as the god Shiva, the individual does not negate the validity of other facets such as Vishnu, Krishna or Ganesha. Or, in more historically grounded terms, they may describe the Infinite as the 'One in the many'. Bricks, plates and vases have different forms but all are made from clay. So indeed it is with the different gods of India. Hinduism, which declares the oneness of Reality, also accepts the seeming multiplicity of name and form.

This profound belief is embodied in sacred Hindu texts of a philosophical nature known as *Upanishads* which began to be composed around the fourth century BC. In part, they embody responses to the criticisms of the Buddha and others regarding the elaborate sacrificial ritual of late Vedic religion. In an oft-quoted dialogue, a seeker after truth persistently questions the venerated sage Yajnavalkya on the number of gods in existence, refusing to accept his initial statement that the Vedic hymns speak of 300. Yajnavalkya ultimately speaks of just one god, and explains the truth about the 'One in the many'.

By the start of the Christian era, Vedic religion had evolved into what we call Hinduism, and texts known as the *Puranas* (ancient writings) were being written. Three major deities had come to dominate the religious scene – the two male gods Vishnu and Shiva, and the great goddess Devi or Shakti (literally 'power'). Today Hindus refer to themselves as Vaishnavites, Shaivites or Shaktas depending on which of the three is the focus of their worship. Earlier Western formulations that spoke of three gods – Brahma as creator, Vishnu as preserver and Shiva as destroyer – and likened them to a trinity were modelling the Hindu world on a Judeo-Christian paradigm. Worshippers of Vishnu, Shiva or Devi visualize the deity as containing all three functions within one form or concept.

A theory of ten incarnations, with one to occur in the future, arose around Vishnu who, in different aeons, repeatedly

descended to earth when evil seemed to overpower the forces of good. Most popular among the incarnations are the seventh avatar as Rama, prince of Ayodhya, hero of the great epic *Ramayana*, and the eighth as Krishna, the divine lover, who is the driving force behind the *Bhagavad Gita*. In the latter (bk 4, v 7-8) Krishna explains the theory of avatar thus: ✓

Whenever sacred duty decays
and chaos prevails,
then, I create myself, Arjuna.

To protect men of virtue
and destroy men who do evil,
to set the standard of sacred duty,
I appear in age after age.

Hinduism's historical tendency to draw varying threads into a seamless weave is evident in the fact that the Buddha was drawn into the Vaishnava system as the ninth avatar, although Buddhists of course do not accept such a formulation. Shiva, by contrast, was not linked to any codified incarnation theory, but manifested himself on earth as and when required. Both gods have consorts – Vishnu's wife is Lakshmi, goddess of wealth and fortune, while Shiva is accompanied by his wife Parvati and two sons, elephant-headed Ganesha and warrior youth Skanda. As the popular god who removes all obstacles and who is worshipped before all undertakings, Ganesha is an appropriate figure to appear on the cover of this book. Devi, the great goddess, worshipped in her own right, is also identified with Parvati, wife of Shiva, and known by a myriad of other names. ✓

While the religious traditions of India present an overall picture of the coexistence of a multiplicity of views, intersectorian strife could be bitter and protracted. Within each persuasion, too, internal strife erupted; thus orthodox Shaivas protested against the practices of radical Shaiva sects like the Kaulas of central India. In addition, southern India witnessed bitter disputes between the Hindus on the one hand and the Jains and

Buddhists on the other. By and large, however, the recognition of pluralism overshadows the phases of prejudice and discrimination that were of limited and often local impact.

✓ The gods and goddesses were frequently portrayed with multiple arms, which prompted early European travellers to speak of them as 'monstrosities'. In India, multiple arms were regarded as a simple and effective way of portraying the immense power of the deity who could achieve many tasks simultaneously. ✓ Deities portrayed in a beneficent mode are given two, or at most four, arms. But if the god is in an active, warlike mode, destroying demons for the well-being of the world, multiple arms are added. ✓ When goddess Durga destroys the menacing buffalo-demon, she is frequently given eighteen arms, each holding a different weapon.

Occasionally, deities are portrayed with more than one head.

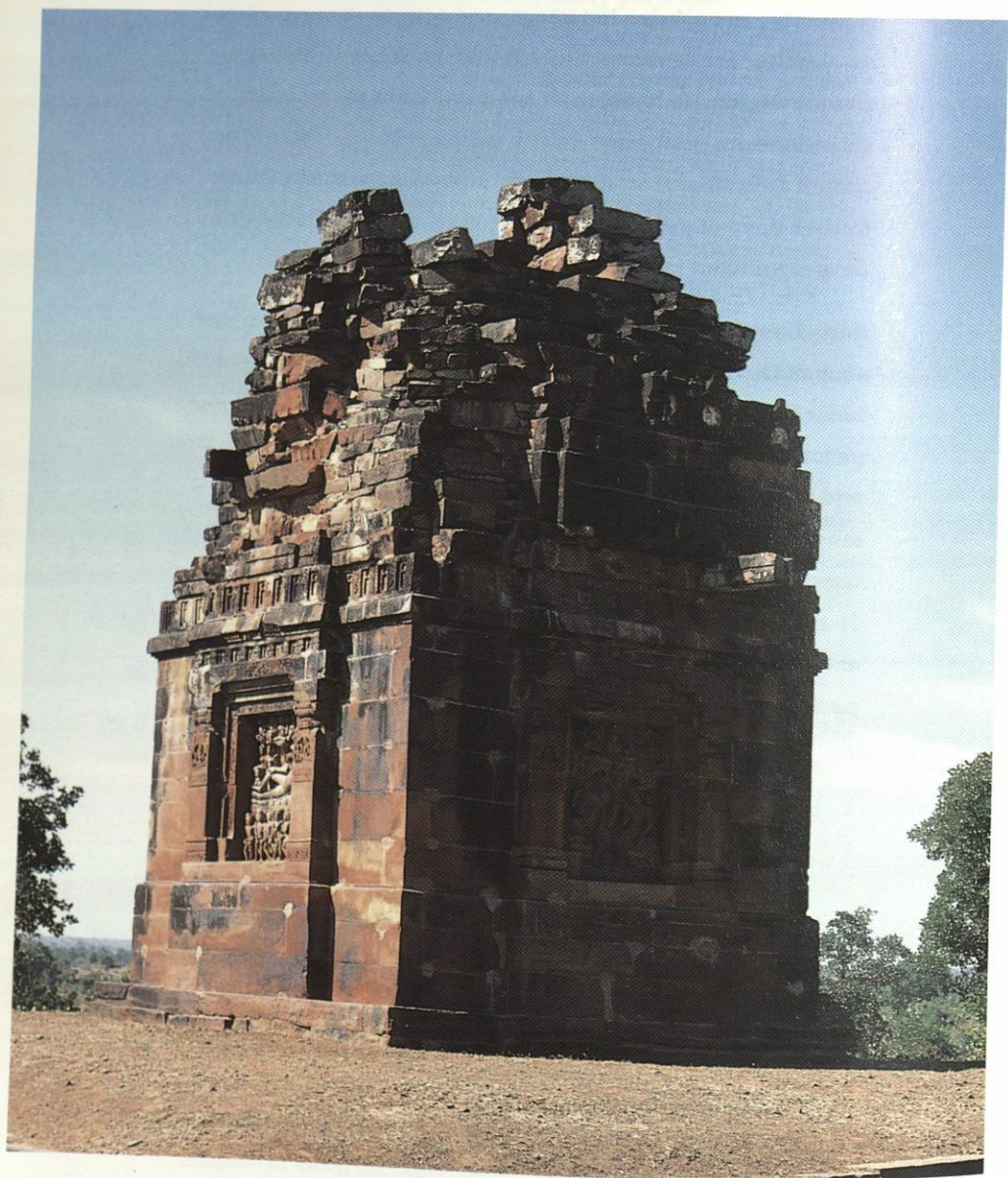
✓ While frequently used to stress the ability of the deity to be all-seeing, such a tactic also portrayed the various aspects of a god's personality, as in the triple-headed Shiva at Elephanta (see 1). Hindu deities are also portrayed with vehicles upon which they ride. Shiva rides the bull; Vishnu flies on the divine eagle Garuda; goddess Devi mounts the lion. Occasionally, gods are depicted as composite images in which two very different aspects merge. At Elephanta we saw the merger of Shiva and Parvati into a single androgynous form that emphasizes the dual aspect of the godhead (91). Another composite image unites Shiva and Vishnu, stressing the essential oneness of the godhead. Most deities are worshipped in human form, Shiva alone being enshrined within the sanctum as an aniconic shaft known as a *linga*. The prime meaning of *linga* is sign; but it came to be understood as a phallic symbol associated with the great ascetic and yogic power of Shiva. Images of gods, as well as temples to enshrine them, were a relatively late introduction, none being known in Vedic times. It is ironic that a religion renowned today for its proliferation of deities began to require images only around the start of the Christian era.

The Hindu temple rose to prominence during the Gupta period (c.320–647) examined earlier as the epoch of great Buddhist art. ✓

The temple is regarded as the home of the deity when he or she descends from an abstract state of transcendence. It consists of a sanctum to enshrine the image, and a porch or compact hall as a shelter for devotees. Since Hinduism is not a congregational religion, its temples do not require expansive interiors. ✓ Devotions are performed daily in a home shrine. There is no sacred day; Hindus visit a temple individually or as a family unit on days of personal importance such as a birthday, or on days significant in the mythology of the enshrined deity.

Early temples were built of brick and an inscription from one such at the Andhra site of Nagarjunakonda speaks of the installation, in 278 AD, of a wooden image of Vishnu upon a stone pedestal. Several brick temples, adorned with carved bricks and terracotta plaques, were built during the Gupta period. A lone, spectacular survivor in the north is the mid-fifth century temple at Bhitargaon (97), with a *shikhara* that reaches up to 15 m (49 ft). The porch is no longer standing. Each of three exterior walls of the shrine carry three rectangular terracotta panels of equal size, apparently reflecting a phase prior to the





standardization of temple decoration when a single, large panel adorned each face. The much-damaged plaques seem to feature Shaiva themes on the south face, Vaishnava on the west and Shakta myths on the north, making its original dedication somewhat uncertain. Brick held a position of great prestige in Vedic times, representing the quality of Mother Earth; but it gradually lost its status and from the sixth century was held to be inferior to stone.

One of the earliest Hindu stone temples to survive was built c.500 AD at Deogarh in Central India (98). Dedicated to Vishnu, it consists of a much-damaged tower above a sandstone sanctum, some 5 m (16 ft) square, which today is bereft of its shrine image. Confirmation of the temple's affiliation comes from the seated image of Vishnu on his coiled serpent seat that adorns the lintel of the richly carved doorway. A single niche on each of the three exterior walls of the shrine contains sculpted panels portraying the myths connected with Vishnu (eg 99). This early organizational scheme remained the accepted formula for the decoration of Hindu temples all over India, even when they later became exceedingly ornate and expansive.

More than one scholar to study the programme of the Deogarh temple has arrived at a theory linking its images with the Pancharatra school of Vaisnava thought. Put simply, the Pancharatra believes in an emanation concept from the supreme Vishnu known as Vasudeva, through his forms as Aniruddha (the creative aspect), Pradyumna (the force of preservation) and Samkarshana (his destructive form). If we move around the Deogarh temple clockwise from the lintel image of Vishnu, we first encounter the god arriving upon his divine eagle in answer to the cries of an elephant devotee whose life was threatened by serpent-like aquatic creatures. Vishnu, poised to throw his discus of destruction, represents the destructive aspect of the god. The panel at the rear of the shrine depicts two sages, Nara and Narayana, who represent the meditative power of preservation. The third panel relates to





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Vishnu
reclining on
his serpent.
Sculpted panel
from the south
façade of the
Vishnu temple,
Deogarh,
c.500 AD

the creative aspect of Vishnu in portraying the Hindu cosmic myth in which he reclines at ease upon his serpent whose many-headed hood shelters him like a parasol (99). God Brahma, who will create the world, sits on a lotus that emerges from Vishnu's navel, while below the god two demons are kept in check by his attendants who are actually personifications of his attributes. Upon their heads are the telling symbols that identify them, from right to left, as the mace (female), discus, shield and sword.

Much remains to be explained about the deceptively simple Deogarh temple that reveals, in fact, a highly sophisticated ideology. Logically, one might expect the sculpted panels to commence with creation and conclude with destruction; the reason for their counter-clockwise arrangement is yet to be resolved. The temple stands on an expansive platform and it would appear, from beams still in place and from pillars found at the site, that an awning was erected on all four sides of the shrine. It would appear too that the temple platform had wide steps on all four sides as well as small shrines at its corners. Finally there is the question of decoration of the platform itself; while its original programme may never be recovered, we know from existing fragments that it featured scenes from the stories of Rama and Krishna.

The Hindu temple, which started out as a relatively modest structure, soon acquired impressive proportions. Temple *shikharas* often rose 24–30 m (79–98 ft), while some reached over 60 m (196 ft). The exteriors of temples in both the north and south are made up of projecting components, or aedicules; these are not mere surface decoration but are conceived three-dimensionally, being embedded in and emerging from the body of the temple (100). The rich appearance of later temples is created by the aedicules being staggered, split and progressively multiplied to create multi-aedicular structures to which rich pictorial representation was added. The construction of a temple was a collaborative process. Priests sanctified a

100

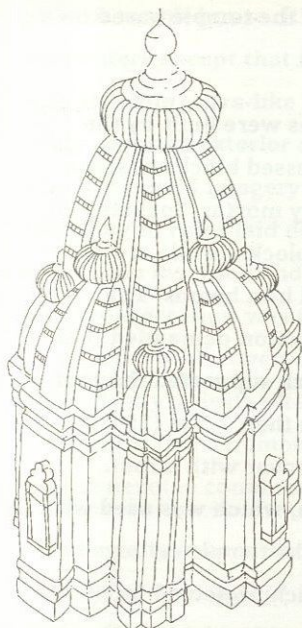
Aedicular components of a temple. The aedicules emerge from the central sanctum core. More elaborate temples have successive layers of components

Above

(A) The Nagara or northern temple. The sanctum core or *latina prasada* is elaborated with (1) *kutastambhas* at the corners, (2) aedicules repeating the form of the sanctum on each side, and (3) *gavaksha* aedicules as wall shrines

Below

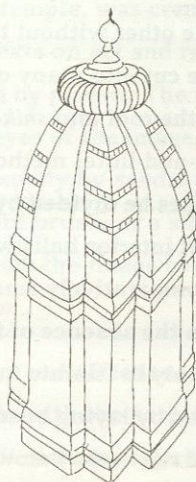
(B) The Dravida or southern temple. The sanctum core or *alpha vimana* (1) is elaborated with (2) corner aedicules of *kuta* form, (3) side aedicules of *shala* form, and (4) *panjara* aedicules as wall shrines



A



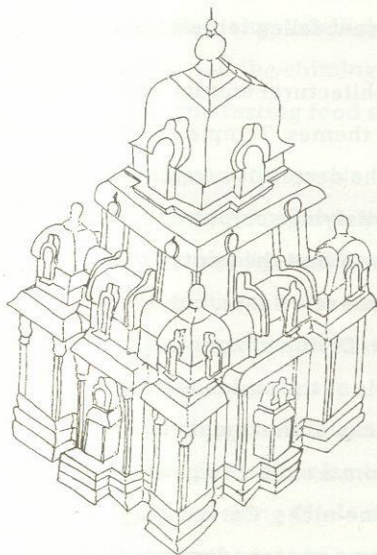
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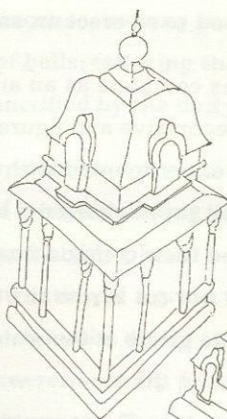
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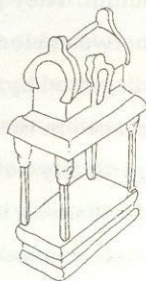
B



1



2



3



4

carefully selected site and architects, following the instructions of architectural texts, laid out the plan of the temple based on a mandala or geometric map of the cosmos.

Building techniques were simple. Temples were built by the rudimentary method of placing finely dressed blocks of stone one upon the other without the use of any mortar. Sockets and dowels were cut into many of the stone blocks, while crucial portions of the roof and *shikhara* utilized iron beams. The simple post-and-lintel method of construction demanded that interior spaces be divided by pillars which supported the roof beams. Most interior halls were no more than 7.5 m (25 ft) square, a comparatively small space to cover with a roof.

However, in the absence of the true arch, which was used with regularity only in Islamic India, dome-like temple ceilings had to be created by laying beams so that each projected fractionally beyond the beam below until a dome-like appearance was created. As temples rose in height, mud ramps were built to facilitate the raising of stone. An alternative method was to surround a temple with circular mud ramps as it rose in height; a twentieth-century restoration at Khiching in Orissa successfully used this method to re-erect an ancient fallen temple.

Once the temple was complete as an architectural unit its walls were carved with decorative and figural themes. Temple architects and sculptors experimented with the decorative treatment of wall surfaces until they achieved a satisfying sculptural idiom. They planned their compositions so that the joints between blocks did not cut across the face of a figure, but were disguised by, say, the girdle at the waist. Divine images to be placed in the niches on the exterior walls of the shrine were generally not carved from the stone blocks of the temple wall. Instead, an image created separately from a single, large stone slab was inserted into an aedicular shrine-niche. Carved fragments found at quarries indicate that, on occasion, decorated pillars and ceiling units were produced there and transported to the temple site.

✓ The sanctum sanctorum of a temple is known as the *garbhagriha* or womb-house. It is hidden, secret and dark as no natural light enters except that filtering through the single, small doorway. Its plain, cave-like interior is in sharp contrast with the richly sculpted exterior of the temple. The sanctum image, like all other sacred imagery on a Hindu temple, was created according to rules laid down in the texts on art and religion; it was then installed and consecrated by priests. The final act of consecration was to open the eyes of the image, which would have been covered, thus far, usually by sandal paste. ✓ Symbolically, priests often used a paint brush, or a silver chisel, to complete this ceremony – after which the image could give, and the devotee could receive, *darshan*.

✓ A Hindu deity is accorded both honour and affection. Ritual worship, known as *puja*, is comparable with the hospitality one would offer a highly esteemed guest. It includes offerings of a fresh flower garland, new clothes, food, cool water, lamps, incense and music (101). Hindu worship is anything but a withdrawal of the senses; rather, ritual sharpens the senses and directs them solely towards the object of worship. *Puja* involves seeing the deity, smelling incense, hearing the chants of worship and the chiming of bells, touching the feet of the image, and tasting food sanctified by the deity.

✓ Creating a stone temple to enshrine a divine image was an expensive proposition, and temple-building was largely undertaken by royalty, nobility and highly placed ecclesiasts. In several instances, the construction of a great temple seems to have been motivated as much by the desire to assert personal power and majesty as to venerate a deity. King Rajaraja of the Chola dynasty built his monumental Tanjavur temple not only to glorify Shiva but also to establish his overlordship of South India. Succeeding Chola monarchs each built a new temple bearing their name in a new town exclusively associated with them, despite the fact that the temples and towns of each of their predecessors were still standing in magnificence.



When a monarch consolidated his empire and achieved territorial control, he invariably built a grand temple at his capital, using it as a statement of his overlordship. Likewise several monarchs in the southern regions of India built temples to Shiva, naming them Kailasa after the Himalayan mountain peak which is the home of the god – such as the rock-cut temple at Ellora built by Krishna I of the Rashtrakuta dynasty (93, 94). Monarchs who sponsored such Kailasa temples were implying that they had relocated the sacred peak, together with its potent powers, within their own realms.

In certain circumstances building a temple could be a challenge to any neighbouring kings who might come forward in confrontation. Capturing the sacred image of a powerful rival and installing it in one's own capital was an act of defiance. To proclaim the independence of the Chandella chieftains, Yashovarman Chandella seized an image of Vishnu from his erstwhile Pratihara overlord and built a temple to enshrine it at Khajuraho (see Chapter 7). Lesser rulers with plebeian, often tribal, backgrounds frequently used temple-building as a means to legitimize their position.

Powerful emperors too appropriated sacred images and built temples to enshrine them within their own kingdom, with the aim of signalling their power and glory. The sixteenth-century South Indian emperor Krishnadevaraya captured an image of the child god Krishna after crushing the kingdom along his eastern border. At his capital of Vijayanagara, or City of Victory, he built a grand temple to honour Krishna. A second temple (185), built by the emperor and dedicated to Vishnu in the form of Vitthala, housed a figure that held significance in the western coastal regions from where it may have been transported. Such reconsecrated images were believed to transmit their potency to the site of the newly established temple; admired by vassal monarchs and visiting dignitaries, these shrines reconfirmed the king's status and prestige.

101
Puja being
performed at
a small temple
in Madya
Pradesh

✓ Like Buddhist monasteries before them, temples operated as economic and banking institutions, lending money, for instance, to individuals and guilds. The temple also functioned as an economic resource, bringing in income from pilgrims. It is not often that one finds impressive temples wholly built by the effort of the common people: one such fifth-century brick temple at Mandasor in northern India was constructed through contributions from a guild of silk weavers who also left investments for its continued upkeep; unfortunately, the stone inscription alone survives. Most instances of temples built by commoners are in the nature of small unostentatious village shrines, generally devoid of sculpture. Every Indian village, however small, has at least one shrine of great local sanctity.